Conference Call Notes: US midterms update with Kyle Kondik

送信者: EG United States 受信日時: 2026-10-27 05:25

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US midterms update with Kyle Kondik

26 Oct 2026 16:23 EDT Listen to the recording

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Democrats remain on track to win a substantial House majority, likely 230-235 or more seats, and Kondik projects they have the clearer path to 51-52 Senate seats with eight days remaining.
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Seven races—Michigan, Texas, Kansas, Iowa, Ohio, Alaska, and Maine—will decide Senate control, and Republicans still have not shown signs of recovery despite late spending.
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President Donald Trump’s roughly -20 net approval rating, versus roughly -10 in 2018, remains the main structural force behind Democratic strength in the House, Senate, and gubernatorial races.

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Speakers:

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Kyle Kondik, Managing Editor, Sabato's Crystal Ball, University of Virginia Center for Politics; CBS Election Analyst
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Clayton Allen, Practice Head, United States, Eurasia Group
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Noah Daponte-Smith, Senior Analyst, United States, Eurasia Group

House: A Democratic Wave Is the Base Case

Republicans benefited from redistricting — the median House district shifted from Trump +3 to Trump +4.5 — but that structural advantage is being overwhelmed by the political environment. Kondik notes the 2026 median district is comparable to the 2018 map on which Democrats won the House decisively.

Current Crystal Ball ratings: at least 223 seats leaning Democratic, 200 leaning Republican, 12 toss-ups. Kondik flagged that the next ratings update will move further toward Democrats. His working estimate is a Democratic majority of roughly 230–235, with 235+ possible — matching or exceeding the 2018

Democratic high-water mark. A Republican hold would be "an absolute shock."

Senate: Democrats Favored, But Seven Races Remain in Doubt

Kondik's best estimate, offered eight days before election day: Democrats win 51 or 52 seats — a view he described as a recent shift from earlier skepticism. Excluding the seven contested races, Democrats lead 47–46 in the remaining seats. Both parties need four of the seven to reach or exceed 50.

Crystal Ball current ratings:

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Lean Democratic: Michigan, Alaska
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Toss-up: Texas, Kansas, Iowa, Ohio, Maine
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Likely Democratic: Georgia, North Carolina

His directional leans within toss-ups: Ohio and Michigan slightly favor Democrats (Sherrod Brown, Abdul El-Sayed); Texas (Talarico) narrowly favors Democrats; Maine is extremely difficult to call but the environment works against Collins; Kansas and Iowa he expects will likely hold for Republicans, though with meaningful uncertainty.

The key risks to his Democratic Senate call: Republican early voting picks up in the final week, weekend polls show Ohio tied, and undecideds in red-leaning states break Republican as they have historically.

The Trump Approval Drag

Trump's net approval of approximately minus 20 — measured across Silver Bulletin, RealClearPolitics, and FiveThirtyEight averages — is the central analytical variable. At minus 10 in 2018, Trump remained above water in states he won by double digits. At minus 20, his approval turns net negative even in states like Ohio, Iowa, Kansas, and Alaska, putting Senate seats in play that were previously safe. Kondik noted this figure is more than double the 2018 drag, suggesting the generic ballot may actually understate Democratic strength rather than overstate it.

Kondik attributed a significant portion of the Republican environment deterioration to Trump's decision to attack Iran, which drove up gas prices and cascading domestic effects. He drew an explicit parallel to George W. Bush's second-term approval trajectory.

Governors: Democrats Positioned for an Outright Majority

Crystal Ball has at least 26 governorships leaning Democratic — a majority of the 50 states — including holds of all current Democratic seats except Kansas (favored Republican) and pickups in Alaska, Iowa, and Ohio. Nevada and Georgia remain toss-ups. Wisconsin, Texas, and Florida are competitive even where Republicans are favored. Vermont's Phil Scott (R), despite landslide past wins, is in a surprisingly close race that Kondik said could tighten further.

Structural Factors: Polling Error, Early Vote, and Campaign Effects

Kondik expressed calibrated confidence in the polls, noting they have performed better in recent midterms than in presidential cycles. He acknowledged the standard risk: undecideds in Republican-leaning states break toward Republicans, as occurred in Ohio's 2018 governor's race (DeWine won by nearly four points after trailing narrowly in polls). He also noted the possibility that

polls are systematically underestimating Democrats in blue-leaning states (e.g., New York, Minnesota, Oregon) — a known pattern — which could make the national picture look closer than it is.

Early voting data, while noisy, is broadly consistent with the polls: Democratic enthusiasm is elevated, Republican turnout lags, and states like New Jersey and Virginia are showing strong Democratic early vote numbers. Kondik was cautious about mail-in vote comparisons to 2022, noting behavioral shifts post-pandemic.

Key Watch Items

1.
Republican early vote trajectory in the final week — particularly in Texas, Ohio, Kansas, and Iowa; a pickup would signal tightening.
2.
Weekend pre-election polling in Ohio — a tied result would shift the Senate calculus toward Republicans holding.
3.
Alaska ranked-choice voting mechanics — whether Peltola clears 50% on election night or requires RCV allocation; ballot exhaustion from the two non-incumbent candidates is the key variable.
4.
Maine RCV trigger — Collins needs to stay above 50% of all votes cast; polling averages currently show Jackson with a narrow lead.
5.
Trump approval trend — any recovery from minus 20 net before election day could move the Senate map; Kondik has been waiting for a recovery all fall and has not seen one.
6.
Spending patterns in nominally safe Republican states (Mississippi cited) — Republican resource deployment in states rated Likely R may signal internal data showing broader vulnerability.

Q&A

Polling error and midterm accuracy: Kondik was asked how he accounts for the polling errors that understated Republicans in 2020 and 2024. His answer: midterm polls have historically been more accurate than presidential polls; the risk in 2026 is the familiar one of undecideds in red-leaning states breaking Republican, not a systematic pro-Democratic bias — though he also raised the possibility that Democrats may be understated in blue states, which could offset each other in the national average.

Correlation of toss-up races: Daponte-Smith asked whether the seven Senate races will move together or split. Kondik sees Kansas and Iowa as loosely correlated (similar white rural electorates); Ohio and Michigan as somewhat paired; Texas and Maine as structurally distinct. He did not rule out a Democratic sweep of all seven but expressed inherent conservatism about projecting a runaway.

Prediction markets in analysis: Kondik does not rely on them, preferring polling averages. He noted markets appear to incorporate his ratings (Crystal Ball's move on Acton to Lean Dem likely moved market odds) and flagged concerns about conflicts of interest and insider trading risk for analysts in his position.

Trump's campaign travel and Republican enthusiasm: Kondik was asked whether Trump's appearances in deep-red states (Mississippi, Montana) signal internal Republican alarm. Kondik said yes —

Republican spending in Likely R states is real and notable — and added that Trump's unfocused messaging has not been well-suited to addressing the enthusiasm deficit among non-MAGA Republicans.

2028 Senate map implications: Democrats reaching 49–50 seats keeps a 2028 trifecta plausible given favorable defense terrain (Wisconsin, North Carolina, Pennsylvania up for Republicans). If Democrats reach 53–54 seats, they could hold the Senate majority going forward. Kondik cautioned strongly against treating midterm outcomes as predictive of presidential cycles.

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